Chapter 4 · Story

“I chose it” quietly becomes “it must be right.”

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

What makes honest revision easier?

A Review failures and compare options afresh.

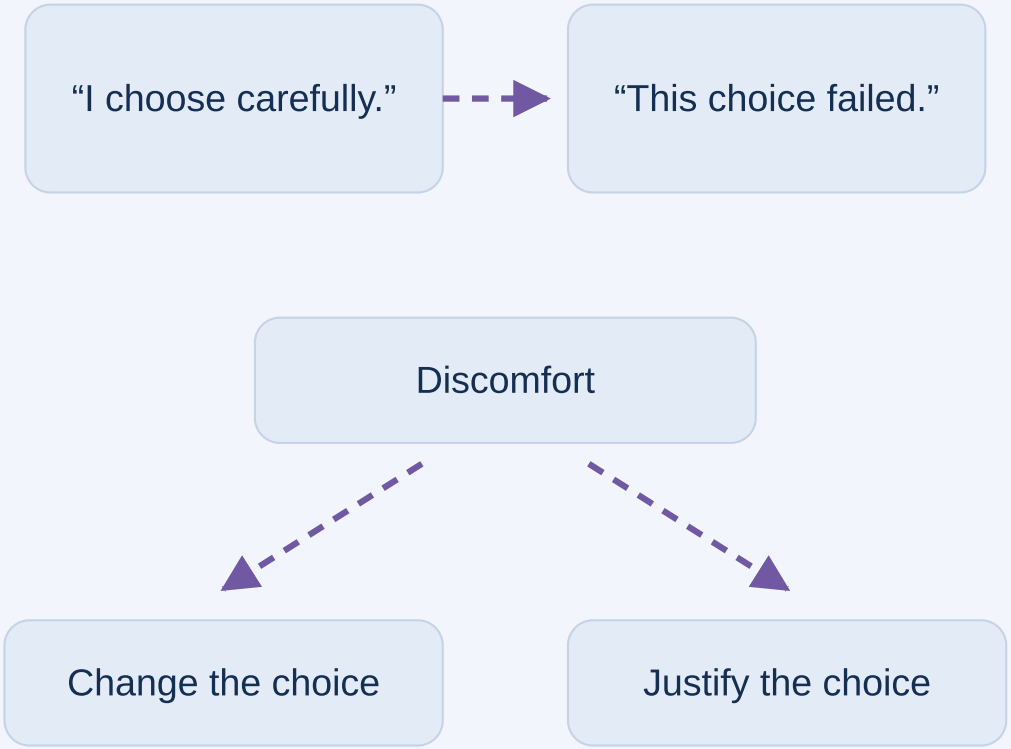
B Remind Maya that a competent coordinator would know better.

C Keep the system until the investment feels worthwhile.

Suggested answer: A. Reviewing failures and comparing options turns attention toward outcomes and the next decision.

Inconsistency can feel uncomfortable.

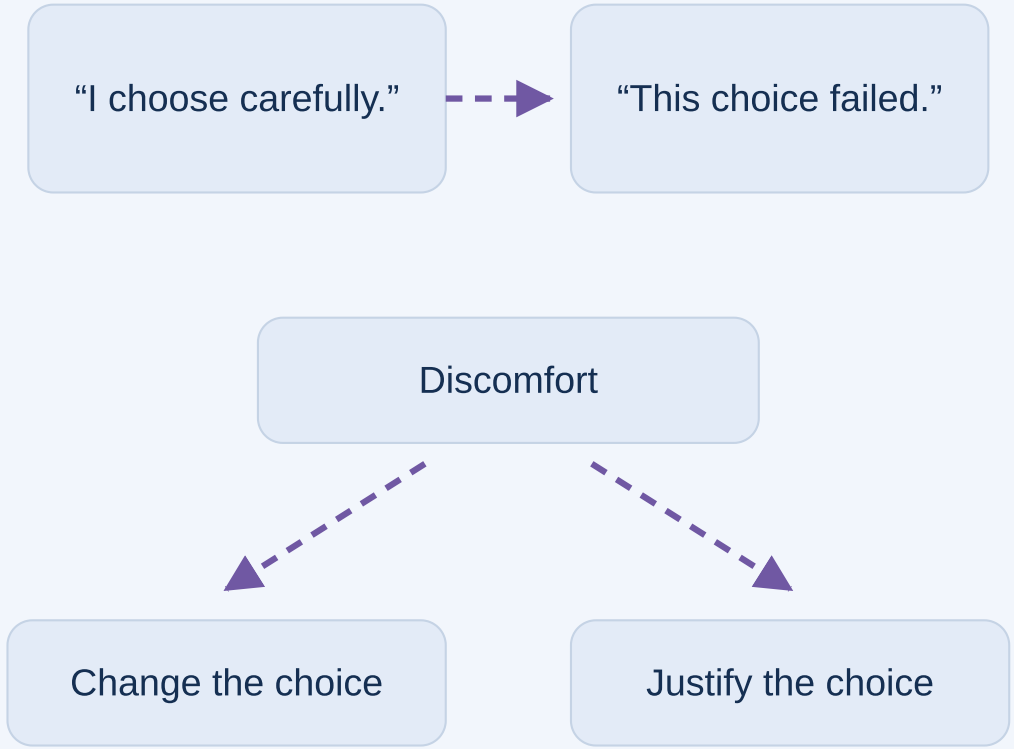
- “I make careful decisions.”
- “This decision is causing problems.”
- Repair the action—or reinterpret the evidence.



Inconsistency can lead to revision or justification.

Give the future a fresh vote.

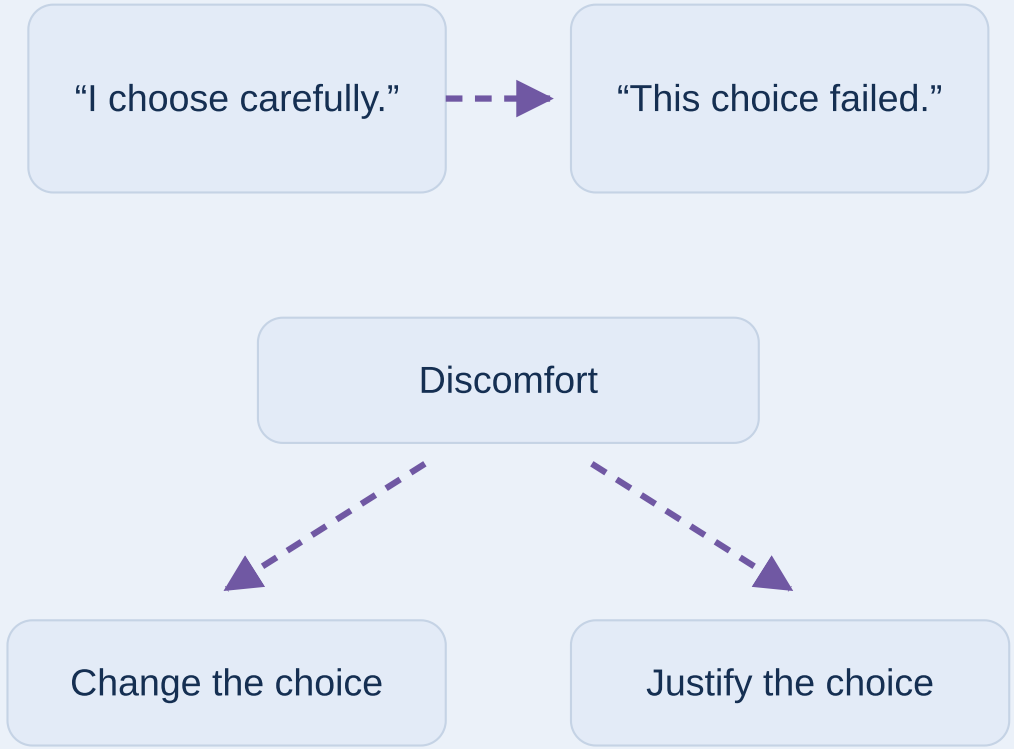
- Past cost: already incurred.
- Future cost: still avoidable.
- Compare consequences from today.



Inconsistency can lead to revision or justification.

What can we really conclude?

Evidence for specific dissonance demonstrations is uneven. In 2024, a research team repeated one induced-compliance procedure across multiple laboratories. The study compared attitude change under high-choice and low-choice conditions. The primary analysis did not support the predicted difference between those conditions. That result challenges the particular procedure tested. It does not settle every version of cognitive dissonance theory. Keep the general theoretical framework separate from confidence in any single demonstration. The linked Vaidis and colleagues study provides the details.



Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Switching costs £100; keeping the tool costs £300 in future support. Benefits are equal. What matters?

A The large fee already paid.

B The lower avoidable future cost of switching.

C Only the emotional discomfort of switching.

Suggested answer: B. Under the stated assumptions, switching costs one hundred pounds and keeping the tool costs three hundred. Real choices also compare risks.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Name two ways to reduce dissonance.

> When can a past investment still matter?

1. People may reduce dissonance by changing a behavior or belief, or by adding a justification. Context affects the response.

2. A past investment matters when it changes future consequences, such as switching costs or usable skills.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Revisit a small commitment you can change. List the future benefits and avoidable costs of continuing or stopping. Write a sentence that permits correction without attacking your character.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.